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KF Introduction of NHG

Chapter 8: *The Expansive Solutions*¹

The Old Testament is full of clear examples of the neurotic expansive type. Think about Cain. He would rather kill his problem than deal with his problem. What about Pharaoh? He was terrified of the growing power of the Israelites, and to relieve his fear he dominated and sought to exterminate them. Pharaoh is a perfect example of the arrogant-vindictive type. He demands obedience and reacts aggressively when challenged. Arrogant-vindictive neurotics must always be in charge. In fact, they don't feel that they have a relationship with someone unless they can control them. It is only when they are dominating others that they feel loving, loved, and respected.

Job finds himself in the perfectionist's dilemma. He thinks that personal perfection guarantees security. In his mind, if he succeeds in living a perfect life, which for him includes offering sacrifices to cover the imperfections of his children, he can expect God's unfailing support. So, when God allows Job and his family to suffer, Job is understandably bewildered. Job's friends ostensibly come forward to comfort him, but instead of comforting him they take advantage of his vulnerability and grab the opportunity to display their superiority. Job quickly realizes that he has lost their respect.

King David is a good example of the narcissistic type. He is attractive and talented, and people love him. David is very public in his generosity and religious enthusiasm, but when someone hurts his pride, he immediately wants to kill them, or he holds on to his resentment and waits for a chance to get even. When his self-esteem is low, he reveals an immoral character; he steals and murders to get what he wants and preserve his reputation. David's pride is built on how his audience reacts to him, and he must save that pride at all costs. Without an audience, the narcissist feels that he doesn't exist.

In the temptations of Christ, we see how Satan appeals to the pride of the expansive type when he offers Jesus control over the kingdoms of the world. The desire to rule and expand kingdoms is a great temptation for expansive types. They are therefore drawn to professions or family situations where their dominance is accepted, and even required. Any kind of kingdom building opportunity is very attractive to them, especially when there are plenty of willing servants. They require everyone to recognize their superiority, and they feel rage or wrath when others will not cooperate. Expansive types need to be right. They must impose their reality on others and demand obedience or, at the very least, admiration. They want to be the ruler of the land.

Satan proposes a contract exchange; he promises to give Jesus power if Jesus will worship him. Worship means to acknowledge the excellence and authority of another. As neurotics, we are also looking for worship. We believe that if we had the power to fulfill our idealized dreams, we would be able to attract worship from others and would find self-worth in their admiration. We could even worship ourselves! Expansive types might imagine that with instant wealth and power they could effortlessly fix the world's problems, and their own, without having to patiently wait for God; they could skip the hard work of learning to trust Him. Expansive neurotics revel in challenge and conflict and feel entitled to have things go their way. They like being in charge because then, when things go well, they need only to be grateful

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

to themselves! Jesus wisely responds to Satan with words that all neurotics need to hear: Worship the Lord your God and serve Him only.²

Expansive types often struggle in the Karis Fellowships training. They think that they should be able to grasp everything they need to know simply by reading *Neurosis and Human Growth* and attending one or two KF meetings. They hope to use the power of their new understanding to achieve a higher level of control and impressive efficiency. They soon learn, however, that Karis Fellowships won't support this egocentric hope. Instead, KF training invites them to admit to themselves and to others that they need help and encourages them to daily examine their thoughts and behaviors. This is very painful for expansive types. However, if they endure their training with patient courage, they will learn how to redirect their unique and essential gifts toward serving their community and worshipping the one, true God.

² Matt. 4:10.

KF Reading Guide

Chapter 8: *The Expansive Solutions*¹

0:50 Weekly/0:50 Weekend Intensive (WI)

Lead Facilitator starts the recording by pressing *9.

“Welcome everyone to the session 8 of the KF *Neurosis and Human Growth* book study. We will begin by reading the Introduction to this chapter.”

Support Facilitator reads the Introduction.

Lead Facilitator: “Thank you. Let’s go to Presenting. When you give us your name, you might also share what qualities you admire in a leader. I will begin.”

“My name is _____. What I admire in a leader is _____.”

- Facilitators open the [NHG Spreadsheet](#) to record attendance and homework completion.
- Each facilitator makes a list of the names of students as they present.
- Each facilitator asks, “Is there anyone who has not filled out their reading guide?”
- Assign the first 10 questions, 5 questions each to two students. While students read, plan the student assignments for the next set of questions.

Question 20, 21, 27 and 39 are open to the whole group, and there are no correct answers.

0:55/0:55 WI

1. In neurosis the alienation from self is the nuclear problem, and we always find what five characteristics in neurotic developments? (187.1)

- A. The search for glory
- B. Shoulds
- C. Claims
- D. Self-hate
- E. Various measures to relieve tension

2. Apart from the conflict between the pride system and the real self, what other conflict also arises? (187.1–188.1)

A major conflict also arises within the pride system itself which produces a fundamental uncertainty about the feeling of identity.

This lack of certainty about who we are might be especially painful and confusing for Christians: Am I a spiritual being or a material being?

Paul may be describing this confusion in Romans chapter 7: Am I a law-abider or a wretched man? Am I a depraved undeserving worm or am I a child of God, destined for glory?

How are we experiencing ourselves? We know how we are experiencing ourselves by how we treat ourselves and others.

When we grow into our real self, we become so unique that comparing ourselves to others to support our pride will become nonsensical. This may be a difficult transition, however. Our habit of judging ourselves and others based on comparisons can be difficult to give up because standing alone in our uniqueness and allowing others to stand in theirs may feel scary.

3. In what three ways can neurotic people experience themselves? (189.2)

- A. **Glorified self**
- B. **Despised self**
- C. **True self (although this is mostly blocked out)**

These three ways necessarily conflict with each other.

4. About what do neurotics feel uncertain? (189.2)

Their identity.

Each neurotic type identifies with the glorified self or the despised self. This identification entails opposite kinds of self-evaluation, opposite attitudes toward others, opposite behaviors, opposite sets of values, opposite drives and opposite kinds of satisfactions.

Examples of opposites:

- Self-evaluation: I am a Don Juan, and I am an honorable man
- Attitudes toward others: People are fun to be with and people are threatening
- Behaviors: I am a loving, caring husband and I am a raging brute
- Sets of values: I want to be financially trustworthy and I want to buy anything I want
- Drives: I want to do what God wants me to do and I want to fulfill my idealized glory
- Kinds of satisfactions: I enjoy having a savings account and I want to spend without any limitations

We might realize that our neurotic identity is just a collection of reactions that help us to maintain pride and avoid self-hate.

5. What are the three methods of solving intense internal conflict? (189.4–190.2)

- A. **Compartmentalizing the contradictory parts of the self** – pictured in the story of Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde.
We can be winning and admirable at work or with Christian friends and be rude and demanding at home.
- B. **Streamlining** – the attempt to permanently and rigidly suppress one side of oneself and be exclusively the other.
- C. **Resigning from active psychic living** – withdrawing interest from the inner battle.
Wise people make the effort to understand what is going on within themselves. Proverbs 14:8 says, “The wisdom of the prudent is to understand his way, but the folly of fools is deceit.” When we withdraw from active psychic living, we deceive ourselves and others, and we become the victims of deceit. We tell ourselves that everything is fine, but we are not dealing with our unconscious driving forces of pride and self-hate.

6. What is central to the author’s framework of theories? (191.1)

The neurotic character structure.

This structure is what we've been looking at in the last seven chapters. Dr. Horney will now begin to describe how the neurotic character structure manifests itself in individuals.

7. What we regard as "types" are actually what? (191.2)

Cross sections of personalities in which the neurotic process has led to rather extreme developments with pronounced characteristics.

8. What would be a more nearly correct term than "types"? (191.2)

Directions of development.

9. What are the three neurotic solutions presented in the book? (191.3)

- A. **Expansive solution**
- B. **Self-effacing solution**
- C. **Resignation**

10. How do expansive types identify themselves? (191.3)

They prevailingly identify themselves with their glorified self.

The imagined glorified self already exists in the mind of the expansive types. If they are not living their idealized life, they explain their failures with "if only . . ." Even without evidence, these types believe that they are already that glorious, superior person.

11. What is the expansive neurotic's chief determination? (192.1)

To overcome every obstacle – in or outside of themselves – and the belief that they should be able, and in fact are able, to do so.

Physical, emotional, and mental limitations should be pushed through and conquered. Expansive types are proud of their ability to keep functioning even when exhausted. They will not recognize that they are not really functioning. In their minds, they can function and therefore are functioning.

1:15/1:15 WI

12. What is the expansive type's most poignant dread? (192.1)

Anything connoting helplessness.

They dread helplessness both in themselves or in others. The helplessness of others reminds them of their own helplessness; therefore, all helplessness must be crushed.

One mastery expansive type said: "Most of the time I feel tears in my eyes because helplessness is the scariest thing that I feel. To be at the mercy of any limitation is terrifying. I express my terror with irritability and outbursts of frustration."

This is one reason why KF is so difficult for mastery types. In KF, they have to face their own weaknesses and limitations and, also, acknowledge the weaknesses and limitations of others. They learn to realize that they are motivated by unseen forces against which, without training, they are helpless, and helplessness is terrifying.

13. What is the expansive type bent upon? (192.2)

Self-glorification, ambitious pursuits, and vindictive triumph, with the mastery of life through intelligence and willpower as the means to actualize their idealized self.

Mastery types are so addicted to winning and conquering that they actively create conflict and difficulties in order to battle their way into dominating and despising others. They crave to feel triumph over life.

14. When we go far enough into the analysis of expansive patients, what other trends do we discover? (192.2)

Self-effacing trends which they have not only suppressed but also hate and loathe.

15. What must the expansive type eliminate from awareness? (192.2)

All traces of self-effacing trends, self-accusations, self-doubts, and self-contempt.

They must maintain a subjective conviction of supremacy and mastery. They need to eliminate any helplessness, vulnerability, failures or guilt, and any need to lean on someone else or ask for help. When confronted with these traces in themselves, their self-hate is very painful and profound.

16. Expansive types must try to maintain what kind of picture of themselves? (193.1)

One that they can be proud of.

They must put up an enormous bluff and live in pretenses.

17. To what are expansive types excessively sensitive? (193.1)

They are excessively sensitive to criticism and failure or to the mere possibility of failure, and to their “bluff” being called out by criticism.

The identity of mastery types is based on superiority and conquering, so failure is even more painful.

Expansive neurotics may have a constant lurking fear that they are a fake, an impostor.

They are very sensitive to being “fooled” by others or taken advantage of.

They lose faith in goodness if in the past they have trusted in something or someone and were deceived and got stung. Expansive types often won't start their KF training because they fear that they might find out it is a fake, wrong, or a dead-end, and they will be fooled again, but this is often a simple externalization of their own fear of being a fake. A student said: “I fear believing that I am saved and then finding out that I have fooled myself.”

1:20/1:20 WI

18. What are the three subdivisions of the expansive type? (193.2)

- A. **Narcissistic**
- B. **Perfectionist**
- C. **Arrogant-vindictive**

The differences between the expansive types concerns the capacity to enjoy life and have positive feelings for others and, also, the ways in which each particular expansive type eliminates from their own awareness the realization of imperfections. Differences also lie in the content of their claims and justifications and in the way that their claims are asserted.

Narcissistic Expansive Type

19. What does the author mean by “narcissism”? (194.1)

Narcissists are in love with their idealized image. They believe that they are their idealized self and

seem to adore it.

20. What characteristics strike you about the narcissistic type? (194.1–196.1)

Open this question up to the group. Examples in bold are from the book.

- Often the favored and admired child and gifted beyond average
- Unquestioned belief in their own greatness and uniqueness
- Buoyancy and perennial youthfulness (which feels fun for a little while)
- Constantly talking about their exploits or wonderful qualities
- Need constant affirmation, admiration, and devotion
- Believe that there is nothing they can't do and nothing they can't win
- Charming, especially to new people and must impress them
- Offer generous favors with the anticipation of returned devotion and admiration
- Always looking for a generous return from others
- Must never be questioned seriously
- A great capacity to overlook their own flaws or turn their flaws into virtues
- Unscrupulous and unreliable
- Doesn't mind breaking promises, incurring debts, defrauding others
- Believe their needs and tasks entitle them to privileges without considering another's rights
- Even the wishes of others may be seen as a threat and received with resentment
- Loneliness
- May go into depression when faced with repeated failure in enterprises or relationships
- Love to hear their own voice, tell their own stories, can be helpful and generous to feed their stories
- Resent those who won't cooperate with their illusion of themselves
- Can't tolerate the opinions of others
- Self-help gurus, pastors, spiritual leaders with an unshakeable belief in their own greatness and their ability to help others
- Turn even mediocre events into an affirmation or something extraordinary
- Actively seek and need attention from others—a kind of greed
- Must impress others, or at least believe that they are impressing others

Perfectionist Expansive Type

21. What characteristics strike you about the perfectionist type? (196.2–197.2)

Open this question up to the group. Examples in bold are from the book.

- Identify themselves with their high moral and intellectual standards, which make them feel superior and judge others
- Arrogant contempt for others is hidden, even from themselves, under a façade of friendliness, because being unfriendly would be “irregular”
- Strenuous effort to measure up to their shoulds and a general dissatisfaction if unable to do so
- A standard of flawless excellence in the whole conduct of life
- In their minds, knowing about moral values equals being a good person
- By insisting that others live up to their high standards, they are able to externalize their self-condemnation
- Need respect from others rather than glowing admiration (which they tend to scorn)

- Believe that their commitment to high standards entitles them to fair treatment by others and life in general
- The conviction of an infallible justice operating in the world gives them a feeling of mastery
- The idea of undeserved fortune, whether good or bad, is alien to them
- Prosperity is a proof of their virtue; misfortune brings him to the point of collapse
- Anything “unfair” conjures up the ghastly prospect of helplessness
- Perfectionist Christian syndrome: “I must appear perfect to others and I learn what is perfect by watching others and comparing myself to them.”
- Caught between the need to lie in order to appear perfect and the fear of breaking the law of truth by lying
- They are often caught in contradictory shoulds
- Good fortune can also be disturbing because “I didn’t work for it, earn it, or deserve it”
- Upset when others don’t keep up their end of the deal by treating them respectfully
- They really believe that they abide by their own standards and are very hard on themselves when they make a mistake
- “To believe that I did the best I could would stop me from taking responsibility for my sin.”

1:25/1:25 WI

Arrogant-Vindictive Expansive Type

22. With what does the third expansive type identify? (197.3)

Pride.

23. What is this type’s main motivating force in life? (197.3)

The need for vindictive triumph – which they believe will restore their hurt pride.

They are also motivated by fear of the future, of being caught “with their pants down”, or of being unprepared or made to look foolish (especially to themselves).

24. What makes arrogant-vindictive people extremely competitive? (198.2)

An impelling need for triumph.

They can be terrified of missing opportunities to get ahead and cannot tolerate anyone knowing more, or doing it better. Their pride system instantly reacts with the feeling that they are not good enough, and that is a feeling that cannot and must not be tolerated.

The need for triumph is so great that even if God gives them a gift, they are not happy because they didn’t fight for the gift. It scares them that they had no control over the gift.

25. What is the most conspicuous manifestation of this type’s vindictiveness? (198.3)

Violent rages.

Brow-beating others, nagging, aggression.

Christians can be sneaky about their rage. They know that open aggression isn’t considered good behavior, so they temper their rage with strong language, forceful feelings, freezing people out, and physical energy. They then dismiss the behavior claiming that they have exercised extraordinary self-control in the midst of what they consider to be great provocation. They can still feel like a good Christian even though the evidence of the damage that they do is all around them.

Virtue stories that excuse behavior: “I’m doing this for your own good. Someone had to do something. I was protecting other people from you. Justice had to be done. Those people need to be punished. I have to force you to do this now in order to prepare you for the future.”

Karen Horney spends more time on the arrogant-vindictive type because the narcissist and perfectionist types are covered in other academic studies.

26. The arrogant-vindictive type is a past master in what? (199.3)

Frustrating others.

They frustrate the small and big hopes of others and their needs for attention, reassurance, time, company, and enjoyment. This frustration is particularly harmful to children.

They also frustrate others in their development. To allow others to grow would mean losing power over them. Arrogant-vindictive types do not feel worthwhile or valuable unless they are controlling something or someone. In their mind, control is love.

27. Which of the claims of arrogant-vindictive neurotics bother you the most? (200.2)

Open this question up to the group.

- Demanding constant respect but do not respect others
- Feeling entitled to having their own neurotic needs respected but utterly disregarding the needs and wishes of others
- Convinced that everyone should listen to them, but they won’t not listen to others
- Believing that they are entitled to criticize others and equally entitled never to be criticized. They feel free to attack others but are offended if others fight back
- Friends should fall in with all their plans and expectations and express no objections.

When their claims are not fulfilled, they respond with punitive vindictiveness. They often intimidate and subdue others, forcing them to adopt a role of compliance.

28. What is chronic about this type? (200.3)

The arrogant-vindictive type is chronically discontented.

They are chronically discontented with how much they have or how much money they earn and who they are. They are discontented with their community, whether at work or at home, and take issue with what others do. If they admire what others have, they judge that what they have is not enough. They chronically crave more control.

29. How do vindictive types do away with the distress of feeling unlovable? (203.1)

They convince themselves that they just are not lovable and that they don’t care.

1:30/1:30 WI

30. Feeling like a pariah, what must arrogant-vindictive people prove? (204.3)

They must prove their own worth to themselves, and they do this by arrogating to themselves extraordinary attributes.

One student said, “I began to understand that if I was merciful or didn’t correct others, I would have to endure so much self-hate. I am making healthier choices now, so I wondered why I feel so terrible. I realized that my self-hate comes from breaking taboos on showing mercy and letting others “off the

hook”. Nightmares started, and I started doing self-destructive things. To be right and to win was the ONLY way to salvage my pride, and now I can’t do that anymore. It’s really painful.”

Vindication means to have one’s position or action validated, to be seen to have value and to be right—even if that evaluation is just in one’s own mind.

31. In actual fact, what do arrogant-vindictive types feel about people? (206.2)

They are afraid of people.

They are afraid of people because they may:

- Retaliate if offended
- Interfere with their plans
- Hurt their pride

32. To justify their own hostility, what must vindictive types do? (206.2)

Exaggerate the hostility of others.

Arrogant-vindictive types take offense very easily and cannot work through their fear. They must attack. They have to imagine offenses and exaggerate their hurt in order to justify that attack.

33. In what do arrogant-vindictive types feel pride? (206.3)

They feel pride in their honesty, fairness, and justice.

They believe that their choices spring from their superior understanding of honesty, fairness, and justice.

They think that they should be above all hurts and sufferings, god-like in self-sufficiency. They must be vigilant, plotting, and outwitting everyone.

Let’s remind ourselves how tortured these people are. For their psychic health, they literally cannot be kind or merciful until they deal with their own neurosis.

34. What trends appear in all expansive types? (207.2)

Self-effacing trends.

Expansive types often feel like victims.

They can act like self-effacing types around more dominant expansive types, appeasing and pleasing and allowing themselves to be abused.

They often feel guilty and tainted. They need community but feel that they don’t deserve it. If they need something, they will fall into self-effacing trends simply because of the self-hate generated by needing anything.

35. What are the three sources of the mixed phenomenon of the punitive attitude of the aggressive-vindictive type? (208.2)

- A. **Expression of vindictiveness.**
- B. **Externalization of condemnatory punitive trends toward the self.**
- C. **Means of intimidating others for the purpose of asserting claims.**

36. Aside from externalizations, how else does this type ward off self-hate? (208.3-4)

- A. **Develops an armor of self-righteousness.**
- B. **Claims that others should behave in such a way as not to arouse in him any guilt feeling or any self-doubts.**

The violence of their reactions is the result of fear. They feel that their world is shaken if they even begin to doubt themselves.

37. When we understand how arrogant-vindictive people are caught in the machinery of their pride system, how might we see them? (209.2)

As a harassed human being struggling for survival.

Arrogant-vindictive people have to constantly ward off the crushing blows of self-hate.

38. What makes the need for vindictive triumph compulsive for this type? (210.2)

The need to vindicate themselves in their own eyes.

Arrogant-vindictive types must justify their existence and prove their value. They need to restore their pride and also protect themselves from lurking self-contempt.

Simply trying to control their behavior with willpower will not help them fundamentally change their reality or how they engage with life. Their behavior will change when they work to explore the root of their fear and discover the causes of their self-hate and self-doubt. They need healing.

1:40/1:40 WI

39. Which of these motivating forces in the arrogant-vindictive type stir up the most compassion in you? (210.2–212.2)

Open this question up to the group. The facilitator might choose one or two suggestions from this list:

- Harassed human being struggling for survival
- The need to vindictive themselves in their own eyes and justify their existence
- The need to protect themselves from lurking self-contempt
- The violence of their reactions is the result of fear
- The effort they must make to not be crushed by self-hate
- The terror of doubting themselves

These children's books might help our children understand and handle their rage: *When Sophie Gets Really Angry*; *How to Behave and Why*.

40. In what ways do the three expansive types try to achieve mastery? (212.3)

- A. Narcissist: self-admiration and the exercise of charm.
- B. Perfectionist: **compelling fate through the height of their standards.**
- C. Arrogant-vindictive: **being invincible and conquering life in the spirit of vindictive triumph.**

41. How do the three expansive types deal with their feelings of hostility? (212.4–213.1)

- A. Narcissistic: **hostility is over-ruled by generosity**
- B. Perfectionist: **hostility is subdued because they should not be hostile.**

Hostility can suddenly break out toward themselves and others, however. Perfectionists go

into “battle mode” if they are thwarted, and the expression of their hostility is often caustic and demeaning.

C. Arrogant-vindictive: **hostility is out in the open.**

42. For the expansive type, the chances for growth through therapy depend on what factors? (213.2)

- **How deeply entrenched in the psychic system the expansive trends are.**
The chances of growth depend on how long you have used these solutions and whether you have built your life around them.
- **How great the incentive or potential incentive is to outgrow those trends.**

The less courageous and the more comfortable, affluent, socially acceptable, and culturally conforming you are, the harder it will be to choose a different way of handling your life. You will have to find a reason to change. Changing these trends will be harder if you have given up the hope of change, are addicted or lazy, or if you delight in the drama of soap-opera living. You might enjoy your rages and the conflicts they create. You might even enjoy digging deep holes of failure so that when you fight your way out of the damage you will experience a greater sense of triumph. You can then experience the euphoria of having rescued yourself, which helps you feel even more special.

The arrogant-vindictive types are fighters, and if they can turn their abilities to fight the “good fight”, they can be very influential for the Lord’s purposes in this world.

The apostle Paul was an arrogant-vindictive type. He may have been able to identify the “good fight” because he had already fought so many fights that were worthless. He had learned to know the difference.

1:45/1:45 WI

All subgroups return to the main group for discussion and closing by pressing *3*.

Lead Facilitator: **Does anyone have comments or questions about this chapter?**

2:00/2:00 WI (approx.)

Lead Facilitator: Dismiss the students and stop the recording. (*9 then 1)

All facilitators, please stay after the meeting to confirm student attendance and homework completion on the [NHG Attendance Spreadsheet](#).

Lead Facilitator: **“Are there any comments or questions?”**

¹ This reading guide refers to the 1991 edition of *Neurosis and Human Growth: The Struggle Toward Self-Realization* by Karen Horney, published by W.W. Norton and Company Inc. New York.